The Days of Wine and Roses

By J.P. Miller

The Characters: Joe Clay (30-40), an alcoholic and Kirsten Arnesen (20's), a young woman attracted to Joe.
The Setting: A walk along the east bank of the Hudson River, 1960's
The Scene: On their first date, Joe and Kirsten walk by the ri ver and share details of their lives. (Joe and Kirsten enter up left. River and city sounds in the background. Kirsten is dreamy. Joe is still full of the day's emotions, but several drinks have helped him to look at things - at least for now - - in a rosier light.)

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: In the fast-moving milieu of Madison Avenue, social drinking is almost an occupational necessity, and one that fast-rising young Joe Clay adopts with too ready ease.

ACTOR: Unfortunately the girl he meets and marries shares his proclivity, and while they continue to tell themselves that they drink because they choose to, it is soon apparent that their habit has become a serious problem.

ACTRESS: But their failure to acknowledge this plunges them headlong into shattering events—a career in shambles, a marriage destroyed, the esteem of friends and family lost, and a child who has become the innocent victim of their obsession.

ACTOR: In this scene the drama begins on their first date in . . . .

TOGETHER: The Days of Wine and Roses by J.P. Miller

KIRSTEN: Isn't it beautiful down here? Like another world.

JOE: (Chuckles) To you, maybe. To me it looks like the same world where I made an ass of myself last night.

KIRSTEN: You did, didn't you? But that seems like a long time ago somehow. Joe - - I enjoyed our dinner very much.

JOE: On, me, too. It was great. And no matter what happens to me tomorrow when I go to the office, meeting you has made it all worth it.

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KIRSTEN: Thank you. But nothing bad's going to happen. I know Rad Leland. He has no moral principles of his own, but he respects people who do. (They have arrived down left, where there is a short length of rail running left to right. They lean against the rail, facing down. Joe takes a flat pint of amber liquid out of his jacket pocket and offers it to her. She shakes her head. He takes a drink.)

JOE: Are you on the wagon? Or you just don't drink?

KIRSTEN: I just don't drink.

JOE: Not at all?

KIRSTEN: I don't see the point of it.

JOE: It makes you feel good!

KIRSTEN: I already feel good.

JOE: Maybe it'll make you feel better! Oh, I'm not pushing booze, but have you ever tried it?

KIRSTEN: Once.

JOE: Well?

KIRSTEN: Senior prom. Spiked punch. I hung around the punch bowl all night, didn't even dance, fell down, had to be carried to my date's father's car, threw up all over his rented tuxedo and my borrowed prom gown, and the car, inside and out, and had a monster hangover for two days. It was wonderful.

JOE: And you never tried again. A real quitter, huh?

KIRSTEN: I guess so. You drink like this often?

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JOE: (Bursts out laughing.) Can't afford it! Oh, I do like to drink, but not to excess, you know. Not often, anyhow. Oh, I tie one on once in a while. Everybody has his little quirk. What do you like?

KIRSTEN: Books. (Pulls book partway out of shoulder bag, drops it back.) And chocolate. (Takes chocolate bar out of bag, breaks off piece, pops it in her mouth.)

JOE: Sugar. If you eat that stuff you probably get sugar highs.

KIRSTEN: (Thinks about it.) Maybe. I never thought about that.

JOE: See? Stick with me, kid. An encyclopedia of trivia.

KIRSTEN: You're funny. I like being here with you. Look- you can see the Prince's yacht. Aren't the lights beautiful? You know what Mr. Trayner told me? Two of the girls stayed with the Prince after the party.

JOE: I guess I oughta be pretty proud, huh? I'm sort of responsible for a menage a trois. (He takes a drink.)

KIRSTEN: Sometimes I wish I could be like those girls. They don't have to be anywhere except where they are. They're like -- I don't know -- hummingbirds. They just stand in the air wherever the nectar is. The world's just one big honeysuckle vine.

JOE: As opposed to one big skunk cabbage, for some people -

KIRSTEN: You know what? It's after midnight, and I feel wonderful!

JOE: (Without conviction) Me, too. (He takes a drink.)

KIRSTEN: (Dreamily) It's funny about the river. If you look close it's filthy. I watch the middle where it's clean. You know what I think? I think I watch the water because I expect a sea monster to come up out of there someday and carry me down to the ocean caves...

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(Joe stares at her, then shakes his head at such an incongruous thought.)

JOE: Midnight, huh? Show time. My Mom and Pop are a club act. You know, songs, dances, snappy patter - - old time vaudeville. They're working some loud joint in Vegas right this minute. Show biz baby. Three years old, right out there with 'em. (Does a little soft shoe, singing:) "Me and my shadow..." (Stops suddenly)

KIRSTEN: (Applauds) More! More!

JOE: I retired at seventeen, joined the Navy. Mom and Pop are still at it.

KIRSTEN: Are they good?

JOE: (Shrugs) You know. Oh, they were on TV, couple times.

KIRSTEN: But you didn't like that kind of life.

JOE: I 'wanted something steady, something with a little class. Like this Trayner account - - class.

KIRSTEN: Joe -- don't hate yourself. We all have to do things we don't like. That's part of your job.

JOE: (Explodes) No! It's not! I want to be a public relations man, not a pimp! (Seething, he tries to control his anger.) Classy guy, huh? Meets a beautiful girl, a girl who believes in things in spite of the dirty people all around her, a girl who reads books, and dreams nice dreams. And what does this bum do? He gets half -schnockered and tells her what a tough life he leads.

KIRSTEN: Actually, I'm proud that you confided in me.

JOE: The great lover.

KIRSTEN: And you did me a favor, too.

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JOE: I did?

KIRSTEN: I love it down here, but I usually have to come alone.

JOE: Alone? You come down here alone? Kirsten, this place is crawling with all kinds of odd balls! You can't come down here by yourself at night!

KIRSTEN: They walk by me real slow sometimes, and stare, but they never do anything. I don't know why.

JOE: Jesus Christ, Kirsten!

KIRSTEN: I dreamed one time they murdered me in those bushes over there, and my dad drove all the way in from the Island and took my body home in his pickup truck. I could see my body stretched out in the bed of the truck on all the little clods and leaves from all the trees and shrubs he'd been delivering. And all the way home he kept talking to my body. The back window of the cab was broken out, and he talked over his shoulder through that broken window, talked a blue streak all the way home. But I was dead and couldn't answer him. The strange thing is, my father never talks. Oh, he used to talk to my mother. They had a very private love affair. Their favorite toast to each other was "Til samen e himlin." In Norwegian that means "Together in heaven."

JOE: Til samen e himlin.

KIRSTEN: (Corrects his pronunciation.) Til samen e himlin. You've got to get the lilt.

JOE: Til samen e himlin.

KIRSTEN: Together in heaven. They meant it, too. After Mama died, he was more silent than ever, almost as though he'd gone with her. (She suddenly

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makes an effort to throw off her gloom.) Well, "gather ye rosebuds while ye may, Old Time is still a-flying."

JOE: You get that out of that book?

KIRSTEN: (Pulls book out of shoulder bag.) No, that's Herrick. He's in Go-Ja. (She pronounces it "Gojay".) This is Le-Na ("Lenay"). Dad gave me these for my high school graduation. He said if I read all the way through from Ab-Bu to Ya-Zu I'd have the equivalent of a college education.

JOE: Hey, you're about halfway through your sophomore year, here. (Hands her the book. She drops it in her bag. He lifts his bottle in a toast.) Here's to your BA degree. And after that?

KIRSTEN: My dream, you mean? You won't laugh? I hope to get a real degree someday, and be an English teacher.

JOE: English teacher. Great. You want it, you'll get it. (Flourishes bottle) Here goes the coup de grace. (Drains bottle)

KIRSTEN: Well, it's just about time to get back to the real world.

JOE: (Finally has the glow he's been looking for.) Time does not exist on the river. (He caps the bottle and leans over the rail.) I ought to put a message in this bottle. But what?

KIRSTEN: (She leans over the rail with him as he holds the bottle out and drops it. We hear a splash. They watch it float away, right to left.)

"They are not long, the days of wine and roses.
Out of a misty dream
Our path emerges for awhile, then closes
Within a dream."

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(They turn away from the rail and walk toward up left. At Center they stop and look at each other. He puts his arm around her, and they continue off left as lights fade to black.)

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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